

Postcard from Heaven

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I

We spent the first night
in a disgusting slum, whose name,
Mission Universitaire Française,
did not advertise the common bedroom, smelly
of bodies crammed into hammocks.

But we were twenty,
even that sleepless night in the barracks,
we found romantic.

Then a week, longer
than the last forty years. Wandering
around the Pompidou
and its crowded square. I remember
music, tightrope walkers,
mimes motionless as statues,
and the endless hours by the fountain,
talking about ART,
with the capitals letters of youth.

Yes, and the fancy coloured tubes,
bright and fuzzy, like a Kandinsky's,
crossing the facade of the museum, evoking
the illusion of false factory, as if a dream.

Amazing to realise that once,
I too, was happy in Paris.

Not that the city has changed so much since then,
 The Seine is still there,
 as the stalls of old booksellers,
 and the streets of the Jewish quarter.

And I still haunt the usual places. Orsay,
 Rodin's house, the Pompidou,
 the long avenues of the Latin Quarter.
 Always something to do,
 a good dinner to enjoy,
 a good friend to visit.

But you never return twice to the same city.

You are twenty only once, naive enough to believe,
 that the city was freshly built,
 just for us. It didn't cross my mind, how cliché was,
 kissing you on the banks of the river, under the moon. Then,
 we rushed to the hotel in Montmartre,
 with its air of brothel barely remodelled,
 that enormous, pretentious, maroon carpet,
 and the giant mirror that repeated,
 the entanglement our lithe bodies.

We sneaked into the subway. Stole postcards,
 read Baudelaire and Kavafis to each other,
 and the city indulged us, complacent.
 It was the middle of May,
 we believed that spring,
 would last forever.

II

The first city,
 exists before you ever set foot in Paris,
 it is made of the stuff of dreams,
 its long avenues stretching in your mind,
 its arrogant buildings,

evoked by words.
 Words heard in a thousand conversations,
 read in a million novels,
 repeated by the poets and the singers,
 turned into images by filmmakers.
 The first city is imagined, and yet,
 you will always—in vain—
 try to return there. Like Ithaca,
 Paris never was. It was conjured,
 by a dirty river, a burned cathedral, catacombs,
 greed, lust, empty stones,
 and longing.

III

You did not visited either the second city,
 the one that you roamed at twenty,
 madly in love, without realizing,
 that you were inventing both, love and Paris.

Those long days,
 walking through streets as new as your eyes,
 those feverish nights,
 almost touching Nirvana,
 the cafes which made you feel an artist,
 the ocasional stolen sandwich, playing bohemian,
 the moon shining above your never-ending kisses.

All of that,
 was just the plot of a soap opera,
 the city was crowded with people repeating the same lines,
 and yet, no one realised. All the other million couples,
 going through the same words,
 strolling the same parks,
 kissing like a disciplined army by the river,
 all were invisible to you, under the blinding light,
 of your twenty years. You never travel to Paris at that age,
 it could have been Viena, or Rome, Tel Aviv or Prague,

you just travel to the city of your youth.

IV

Then many cities follow,
each one piling above the previous,
ordered in time, like archeological layers,
and at the same time overlapping,
as if they were made of mist.

You return to Paris so often across the years,
quick visits, work trips, conferences,
each time renewing your covenant with the place.

The magic is gone, yet,
a good feeling persists,
you become a friend of the same streets,
and buildings, and museums, and bookstores,
that once were your lovers.

As if meeting an old flame,
there is among both of you the intimacy,
which only gives the memory of naked bodies,
under clean sheets. Yet the passion has passed,
you see wrinkles and decay where once,
you only saw desire.

V

But then you return to the city with your children,
and all the angels of Heaven,
rush to greet you.

You walk Paris again, they are by your side,
your girl is eleven, and she carries the map,
to sail the hostile underground and ensure,
you all get to Disney. Her mom has told her,
Daddy won't find his way, he is half blind,
and can't navigate the dark waters
of the Subway.

So she is taking care of you, firmly,
holding your hand. But your son's grip,
is even stronger. He is seven, his job,
is to be your bodyguard. His stern gaze,
scares away trolls and goblins.

All the sudden,
Your eyes are open again,
your heart is pounding with a love
you can hardly survive.
Not that selfish invention of yesteryear,
but something so deep and burning,
that the city becomes real,
for the first time.

VI

Eventually you return to Paris,
as an old man. There is something in the air,
that rejects you, the old covenant, good for so long,
thorn to pieces.

What is it? It takes you a while to realise the reason.
You still move around, watching everything and everybody,
absorbing equally land and people,
with your searching eyes.

When you were younger,
that burning stare,
was a weapon. Gazes were crossed, like swords,

but no blood was spilled. Girls
looked back, sometimes,
sparks flew the night.

Now, if you are not careful,
you will be taken by a loony,
or worst, a lecher.
You need to remind yourself,
that old men should avoid
eye contact with the youth,
smile benignly —trying not to drool—,
and hope to be spared.

VII

But then, again,
you return to the city with your children.

Your daughter is twenty, still holds you hand,
talks non-stop about her recent love-boy,
he is coming to meet her,
they will walk the same streets,
and kiss in the same corners,
that one smiled at you,
they are inventing, one more time,
the same old tale,
yet so new.
The same old lies,
yet so true.

Your son is eighteen,
want to be a scientist like mom and dad,
when he was small,
he wanted to work in the same place,
that both of you, now,
he is moving to Paris, away from home,
to fulfil his dreams.

How strange, to feel so happy,
and so hopeless. So proud of him,
as a king watching his prince being knighted, yet,
a black hole eating your heart.

Turns out,
love was not all those will-o'-the-wisps,
vanishing in the night,
as the light of fireflies.

Love was something else,
made of clay and ashes,
made of blood and tears,
made of guilt and forgiveness,
made of years.

Turns out,
Paris was not Paradise,
but it can still be,
a postcard from Heaven.

The clochard

The clochard who sleeps under the doorway
of that building in the Montparnasse boulevard,
owns a dirty mattress covered by a dirty rag,
a pillow,
and four books.

Often, he sits perched, like an old vulture,
over the grids of the subway venting grids,
barefoot, whitebearded, a bottle of vodka at hand,
warmed by the alcohol and the fumes from the underground,
his books keep him company.

Sometimes he stares at nothingness,
as if searching for the meaning of life,
some times he reads,
royal and languid as a lord in his library.

Nearby the tourists,
expend the money he need to survive a full month,
in a ticket to the modernist museum.